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I DECIDED NOT TO WASTE any time in trying to get to know the new Soviet leader. When George Bush went to Moscow for Konstantin Chernenko's funeral, he took an invitation from me to Gorbachev for a summit conference in the United States. "You can be assured of my personal commitment to working with you and the rest of the Soviet leadership in serious negotiations," I wrote. "In that spirit, I would like you to visit me in Washington at your earliest convenient opportunity. I recognize that arriving at an early answer may not be possible. But I want you to know that I look forward to a meeting that could yield results of benefit to both our countries and to the international community as a whole."

Gorbachev replied two weeks later. In doing so, he completed the first round of a correspondence between us that was to last for years and encompass scores of letters. As I look back on them now, I realize those first letters marked the cautious beginning on both sides of what was to become the foundation of not only a better relationship between our countries but a friendship between two men.

Gorbachev thanked me for sending George to the funeral and expressed less hostility than I'd come to expect from Soviet leaders. He said he was amenable to holding a summit, but not necessarily in Washington. Overall, his letter was encouraging. Except for some formalities, here is the complete text of his letter:

> Our countries are different by their social systems, by the ideologies dominant in them—but we believe that this should not be a reason for animosity. Each social system has the right to life, and it should prove its